

# ‘Descending into the冥冥’ Iconography in Early Cypriot Chalcolithic

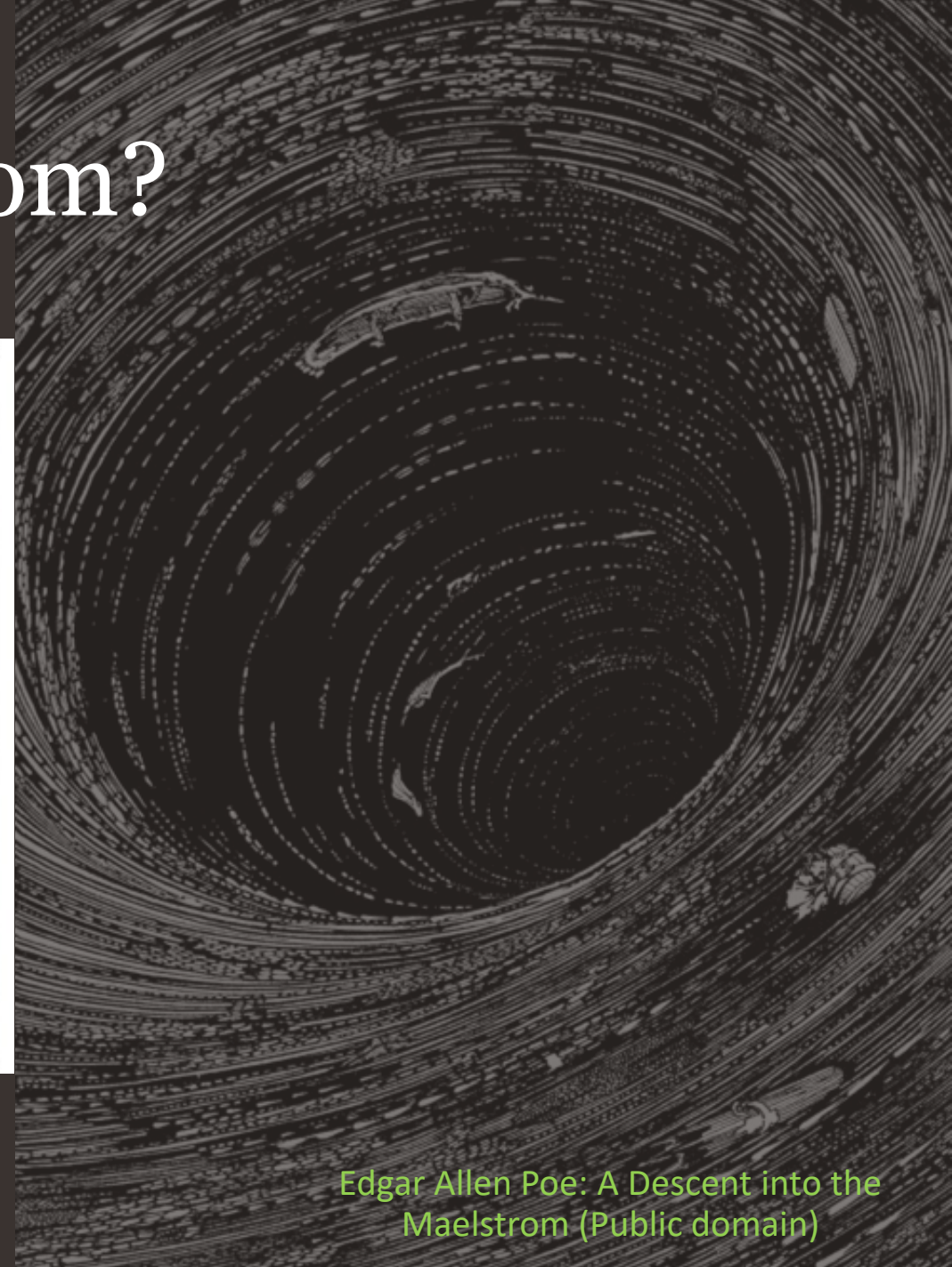
Christopher Nunn  
Swedish Institute at Athens and National  
University of Athens  
Postdoctoral fellow



# A Descent into the Maelstrom?



<https://abc7.com/whirlpool-greek-islands-in-corfu-off-the-coast-of-island/2051465/>



Edgar Allen Poe: A Descent into the  
Maelstrom (Public domain)



# Material agency

Robin Boast (1997, “A Small Company of Actors: A Critique of Style”, *Journal of Material Culture*):

*“...partners in the social conversation of being.”*



National Archaeological Museum, Athens (NAMA)



# Embedment of the Environment



By author, Eremonisia



By author, Folegandros





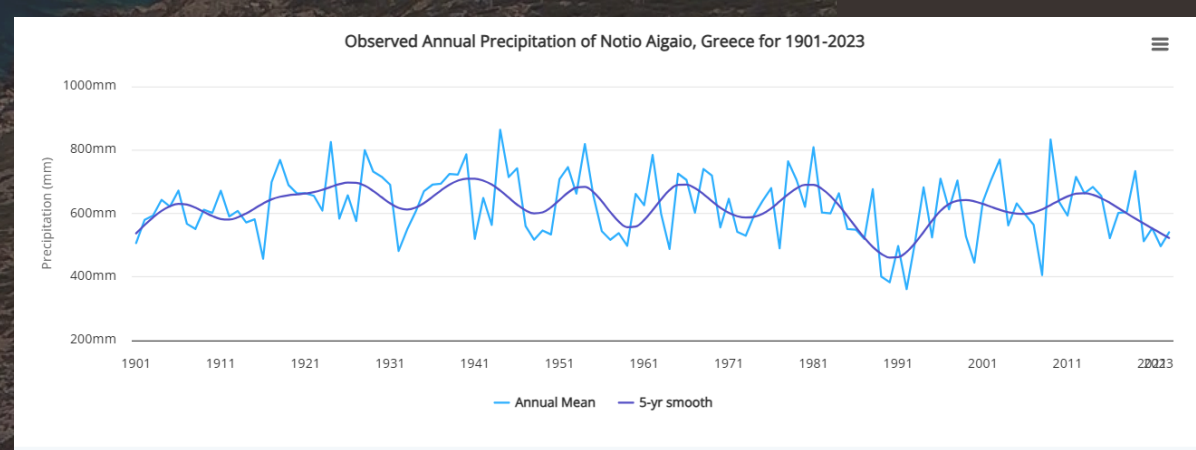
# Geographical and Cultural Context

By author, QGIS  
Basemap: ESRI Imagery

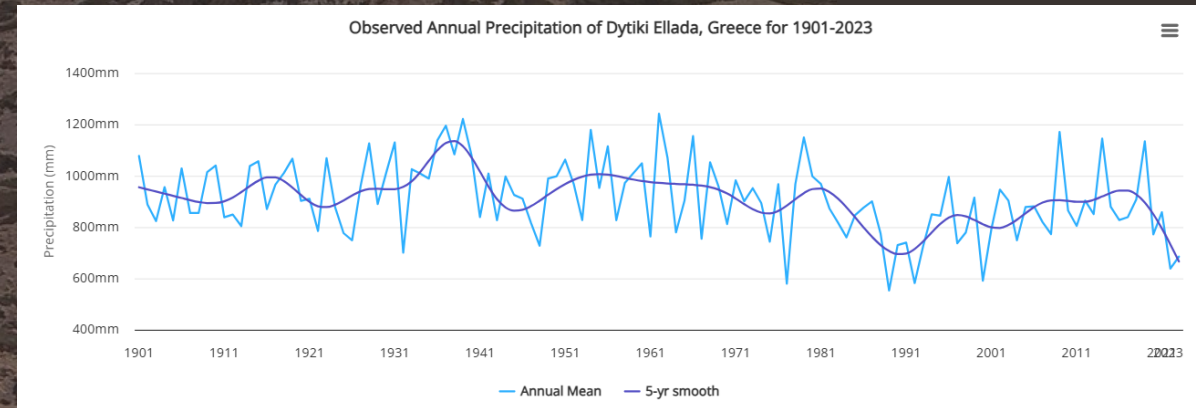


# Geology

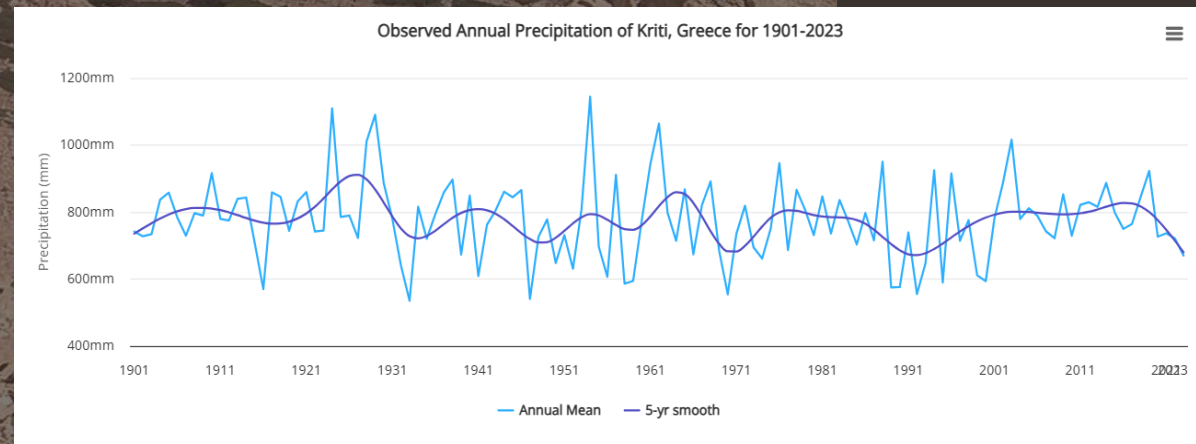
**Aegean mean:  
c. 650 mm yearly**



**West Greece mean:  
c. 950 mm yearly**



**Crete mean:  
c. 800 mm yearly**





# Early Cycladic 'Civilisation'

- Early Cycladic II (EC II) period: 2760–2400 BCE
- Social, Artistic, and Technological developments
- Most settlements during this time were small and located along the coast.
- Most less than 50 people with only a handful of larger settlements

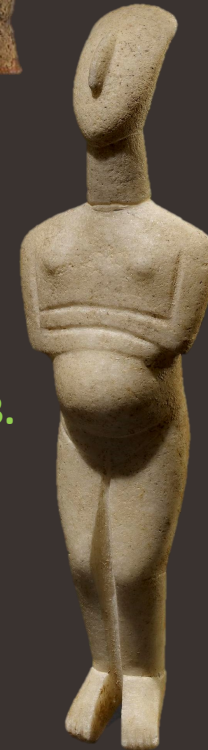
1.



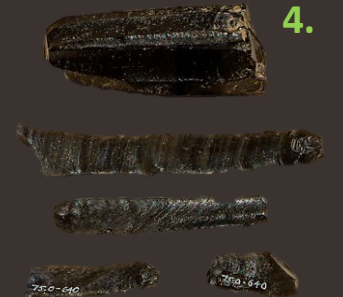
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3.



4.



1. NAMA

2, 3, 4. Museum of Cycladic Art (MCA)



# Cycladic Networks

- Maritime connections were crucial.
- Fostered social and cultural unity.
- The sea as a vital conduit for communication, trade, and the exchange of ideas.
- Early Cycladic cultures key intermediaries in a network linking Greece, Crete, and the coastal regions of Anatolia.



By author, QGIS, Basemap: ESRI Imagery

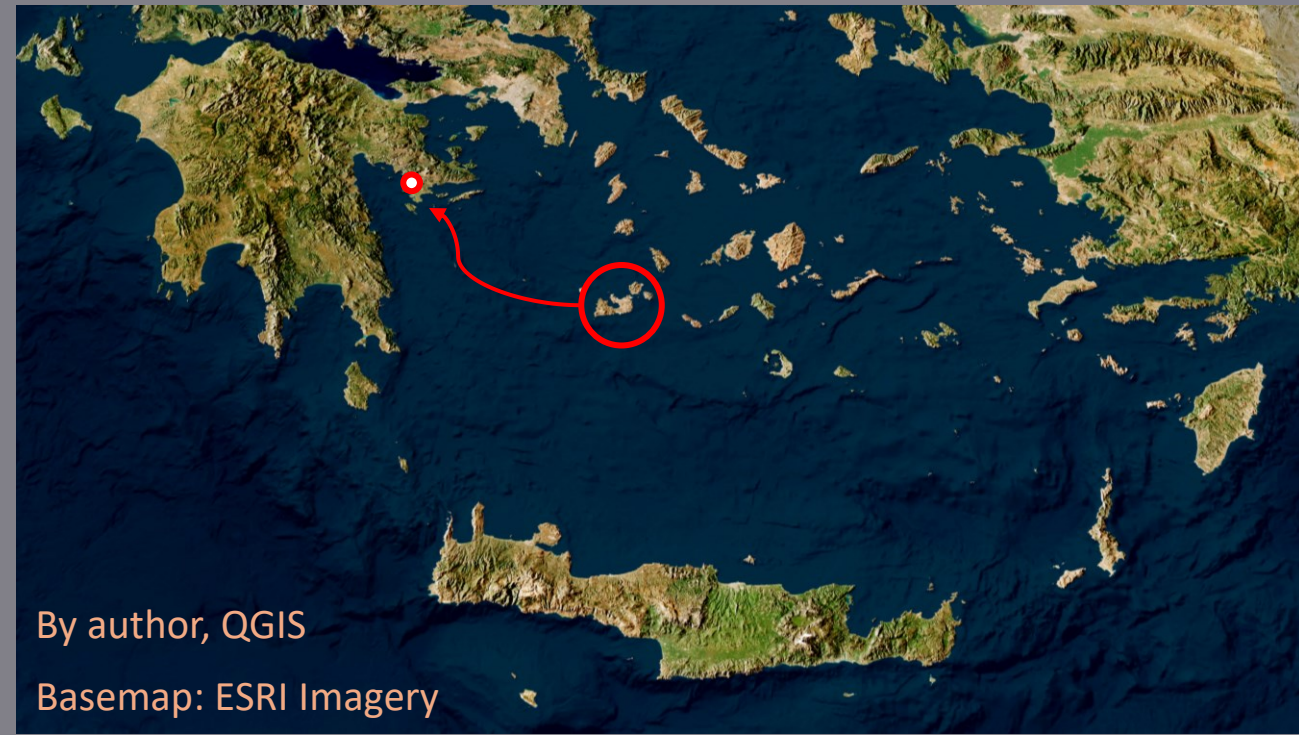


NAMA



# Early Cycladic Boats and Maritime Practices

- Obsidian indicates inter-island travel in early Greek prehistory times.
- Melos the primary source of obsidian found on Greek mainland during the Upper Paleolithic (c. 12,000 BCE).
- Maritime activities occurred after Melos became an island.
- Colonisation of Cycladic Islands from Middle Neolithic period onwards
- Island-focused network emerged, largely independent of the Greek mainland.



Franchthi Cave, by author



MCA



# Cycladic Boats



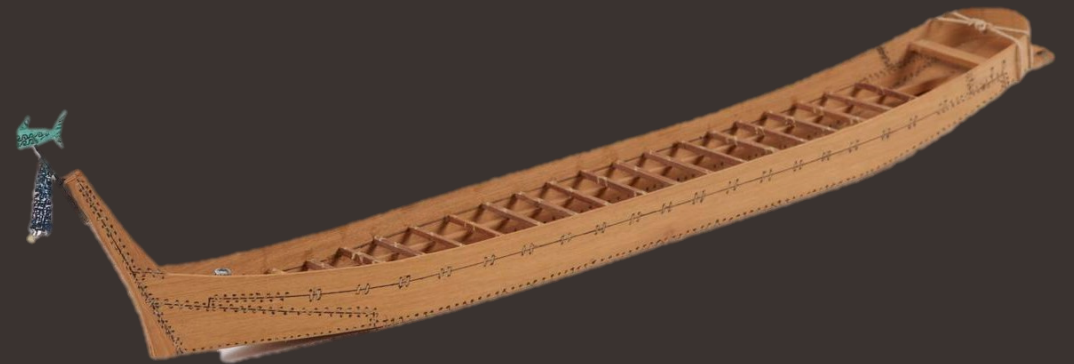
Monoxylon II



NAMA



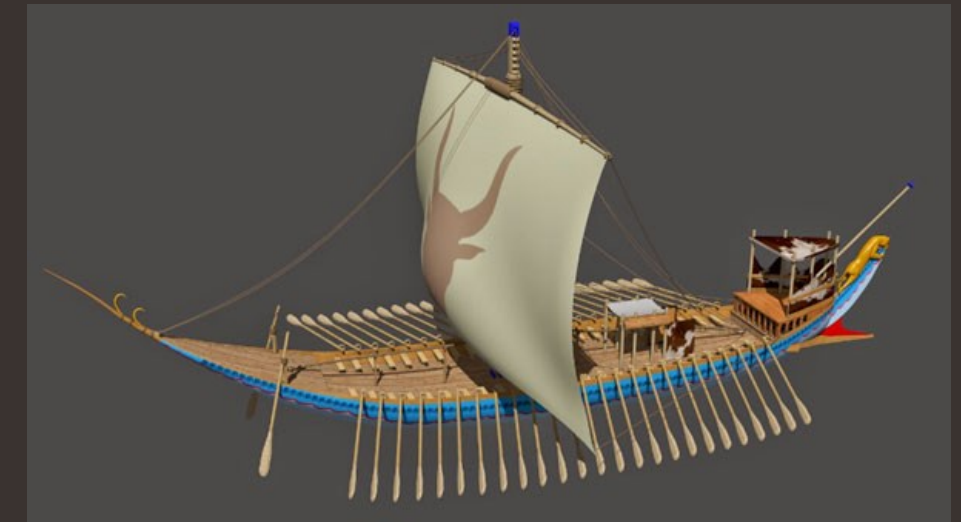
Tzalas 1995



Science Museum Group



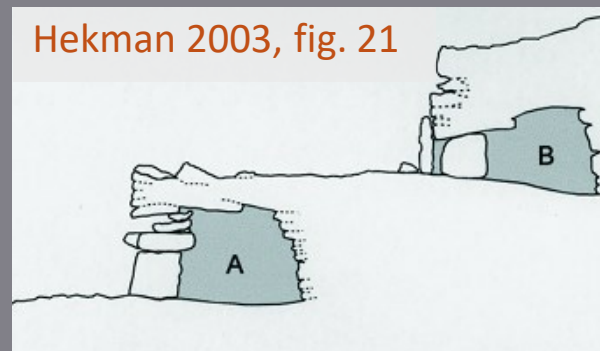
# Sailing boats





# Chalandriani Cemetery

- Chalandriani (Syros) a key burial site--over 600 graves.
- Tombs of the Built cist-type
- Early excavation (Christos Tsountas) lacked modern documentation, omitting vital osteological data.
- Analysis depends on material culture due to data loss.
- Illicit excavations has further hindered comparative studies.





# Cycladic Graves

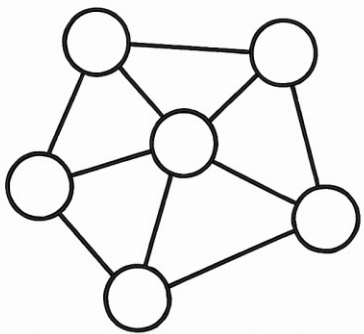


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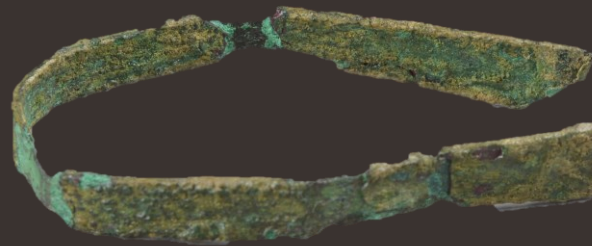
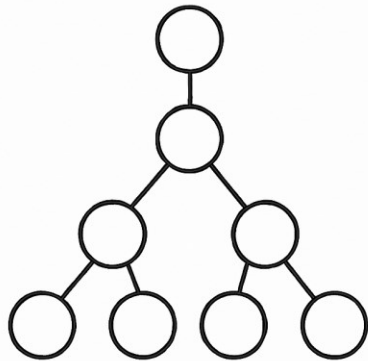
Tsountas 1899, pl. 3

HETERARCHY



By author

HIERARCHY



British Museum (BM)



# An 'International Spirit'

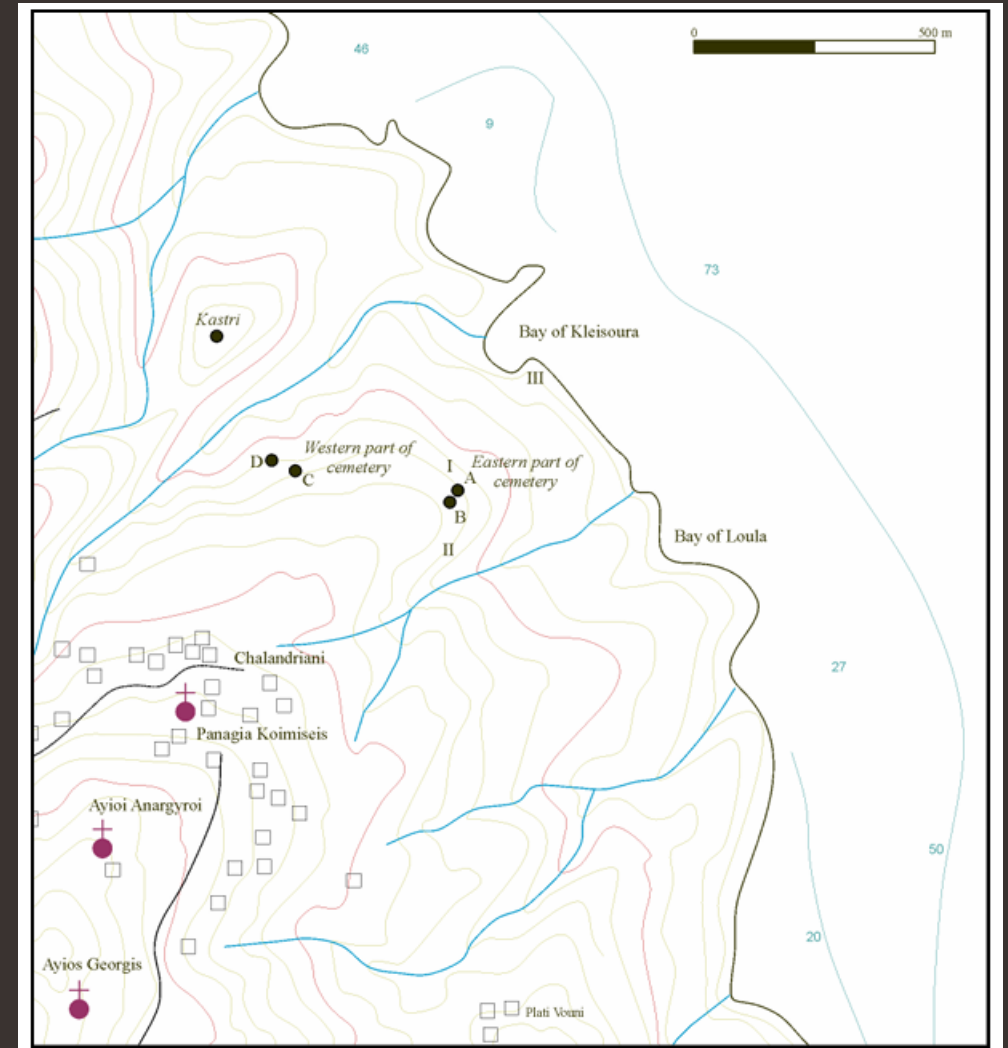
- Cycladic Communities small-scale, likely kin-based.
- Chalandriani more complex socially.
- Imported objects and craft expertise.
- External connections.
- Chalandriani residents likely managed maritime trade routes.
- Gained influence and prestige through interregional exchange networks.





# Chalandriani Cemetery

- Emergent heterarchical structures rather than rigid hierarchies.
- Evidence of external contacts underscores the connection to maritime practices.
- Critical context for understanding the symbolic significance of frying-pan representations.



Hekman 2003, fig. 13

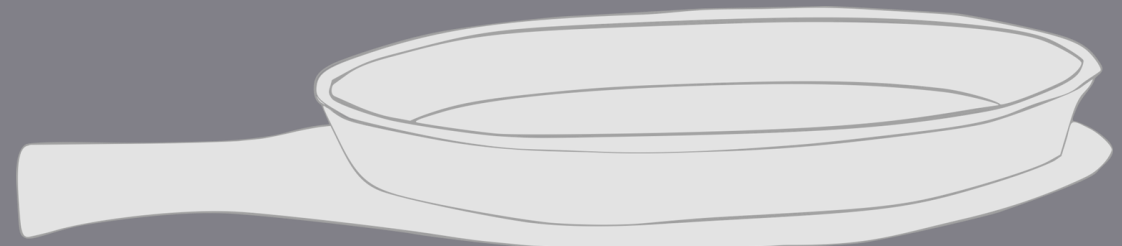


# Frying Pan Morphology

- Despite the name, they were not used for frying or cooking.
- Typically, flat and pan-shaped, featuring a shallow circular base, raised edges, and one or two horizontal handles.
- Most are ceramic, though rare examples are fashioned from stone



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Tsountas 1898, fig. 11a.



# Frying Pan Antecedents

- Bratislava lids, a Later Neolithic pottery form from the southern Balkans.
- Spread to Greece during the Late Neolithic to Early Bronze Age transition.
- Similar forms appear in the Final Neolithic/Early Helladic I phase, including at the Tsepi cemetery in Attica.



Tsepi cemetery





# Frying Pan Decoration





# Female Symbolism





# A Mortuary Type (in the Cyclades)

- Cycladic frying pans found mainly in cemetery sites (decorated)
- Mainland frying pans linked to domestic contexts (undecorated).
- Funerary or ritual significance in the Cycladic islands.
- Utilitarian purpose on the Greek mainland?
- Islandisation? (*Culture divergence through island isolation*)



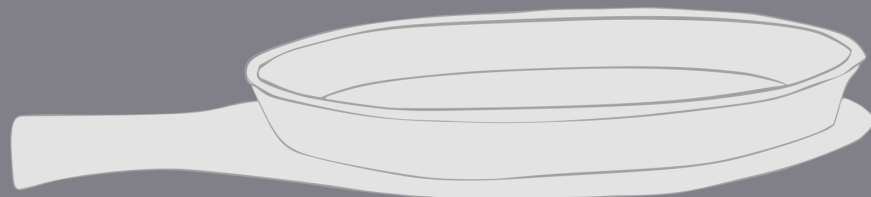


# Function and Interpretation

- Interpreted as mirrors (Mellink 1956; Papathanassoglou & Georgouli 2009).
- Commonly placed near the deceased's head in burials.
- Vinegar-water can create a reflective surface.
- Intricate decoration would remain unseen when filled with liquid.



Papathanassoglou & Georgouli 2009



Tsountas 1898, fig. 11a.



# Salt Pans?

- Salt pans for evaporation-based salt extraction.
- Examples inland challenge this theory due - distance from coastal saltwater sources.
- Decorative designs obscured if used exclusively for salt production, raising practical doubts.



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# Other interpretations?

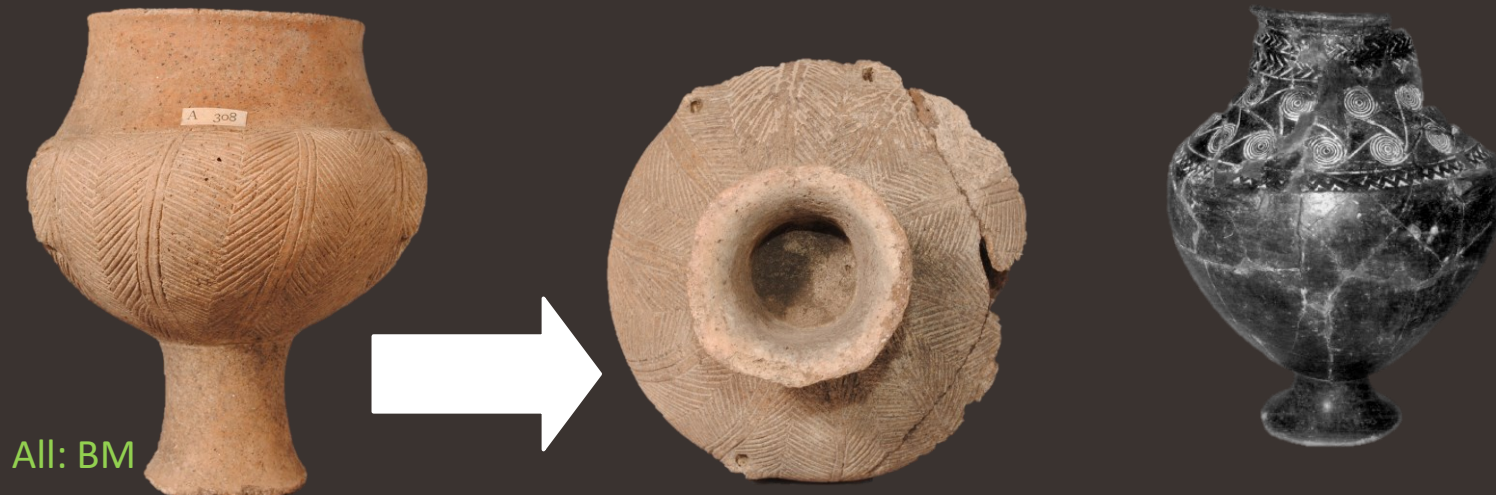
- Drum? (Marinatos 1959)—lack of attachment holes challenges this theory.
- Astronomical tool? (Faucounau 1978; Tsikritsis *et al.* 2015)—impractical due to shallow, handheld design.
- Both theories overlook the prominent decorative emphasis on their bases.





# Libation/Offering Vessel

- Frying pan decoration had active, agentic potential only when visible.
- Libation or offering vessel use aligns with this visibility, unlike other interpretations.
- EC pottery typically features decoration in maximally visible areas.
- Extensive decoration suggests frying pans were not used in ways that obscured their design.



## Interpreting 'frying-pan' function

Diagram by author using images from Pixabay, Hekman 2003 and Tsountas 1899

• **Libation vessel** (Coleman 1985; Betancourt 2012)

• **Mirror** (Mellink 1956; Getz-Gentle; Papathanassoglou & Georgouli 2009)

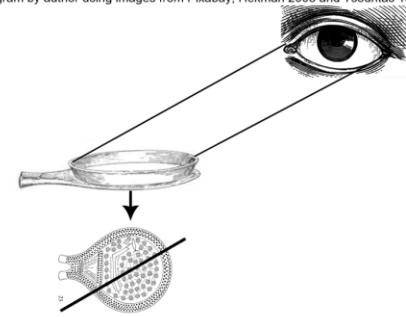
• **Salt pan** (Dumas (1993; Siotis & Aloupi-Siotis 2020)

• **Cult object** (Zchietzchmann 1935; Goodison 2006)

• **Cosmic-calendar** (1978; Tsikritsis et al. 2015)

• **Pigment-palette**

• **Drum** (Marin)

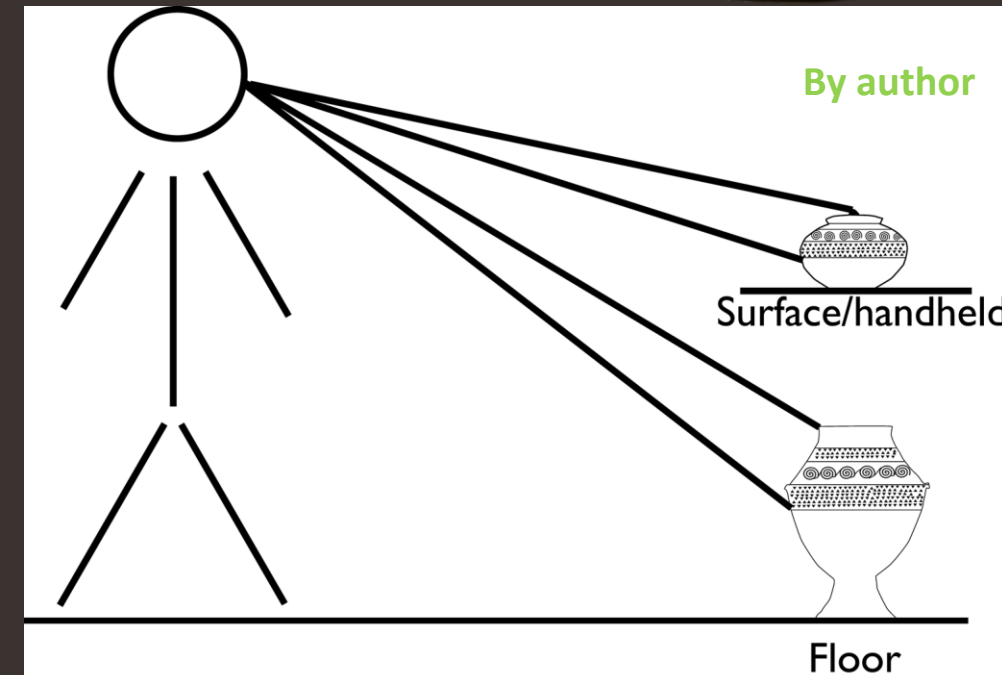


**Need for the incorporation of the decorated elements into active praxis**



Symposium Egejskie  
19-20 June 2023 | Christopher Nuttall  
Postdoc

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# Celestial Iconography

- Often feature celestial motifs (e.g., star shapes, sun-disc imagery).
- Rituals involving celestial phenomena or sun deities?
- Getz-Gentle (1996): Cycladic deity tied to life, death, and regeneration.
- Goodison (2006): Female sun goddess association.
- Susan Sherratt: Ishtar--fertility, navigation, and power.





# Seafaring Iconography

- Maritime motifs and female genitalia are prominent decorative elements.
- Cyprian Broodbank (2000): societal values of seafaring, risk-taking, and prestige.
- Symbolic association between maritime prowess, fertility, and identity.



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# Descending the Maelstrom?

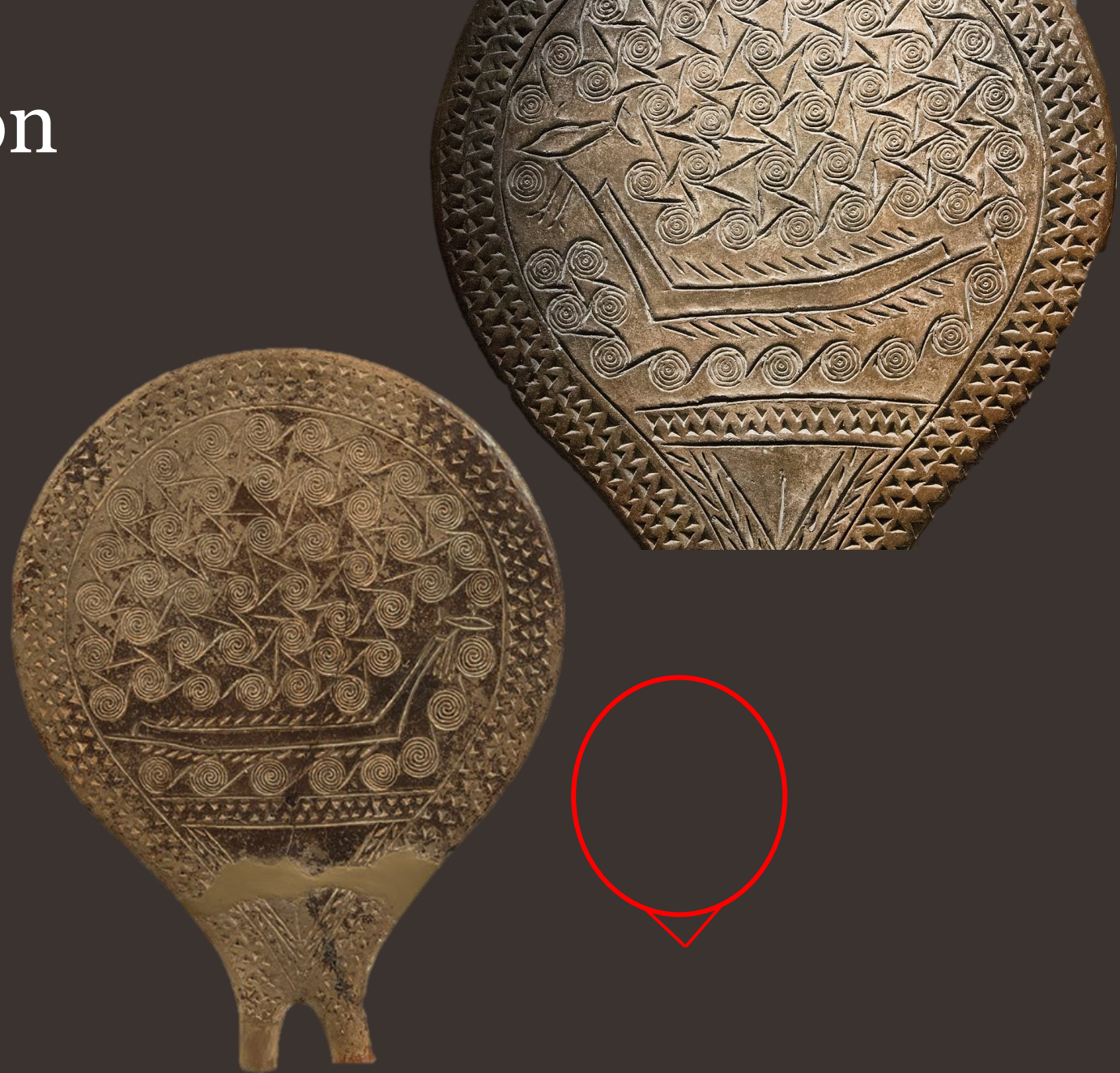
- Notable concentration of maritime motifs on frying pans at Chalandriani.
- Frying pans 6% of ceramic assemblage.
- Inclusion in burial contexts suggests significance beyond utilitarian use.





# Symbolic interpretation

- Iconographic elements combine maritime imagery, spirals, and representations of female genitalia.
- Symbolic narrative links fertility, the sea, rebirth, and regeneration, especially in funerary contexts.
- The oval shape evokes feminine symbolism, framing maritime imagery as a womb.
- The frying pan may symbolize societal renewal through connections to seafaring and birth.





# Spirals and Concentric Circles

- Spirals and concentric circles are consistently associated with maritime imagery.
- Common motif in Aegean Bronze Age.
- Interpretations include cyclical renewal, dynamic movement, and aesthetic motifs.
- Symbolic representation of the sea.



By author





# Adverse weather phenomena

- Spirals depict turbulent sea conditions.
- Real environmental phenomena around Syros?
- Representations assert maritime expertise and skill.
- Spirals may symbolize stormy conditions.



Source:  
<https://abc7.com/whirlpool-greek-islands-in-corfu-off-the-coast-of-island/2051465/>



Background: Pixabay



# Comparanda – Mycenaean Greece

Background: NAMA



Gold Vapheio Cup in relief with Bull Capture, NAMA



The "Gryphon Warrior", Pylos (ASCSA)



The "Lion Hunt Dagger", NAMA



The "Warrior Vase", NAMA



# Final Thoughts

- Decorated frying pans likely served as libation vessels, emphasizing their elaborate decoration during ritual use.
- Symbolic narratives link the maritime sphere with ancestral commemoration in funerary contexts.
- Seafaring motifs connect fertility, regeneration, and the sea as a metaphysical conduit between the living and the dead.
- Reinforces individual and collective identities within the maritime-focused society of Chalandriani on Syros.



By author



# Thank you!

Special thanks to the IPR organisers for their understanding.

Any questions?

[chrisnuttallacademia@gmail.com](mailto:chrisnuttallacademia@gmail.com) /  
[chris.nuttall@sia.gr](mailto:chris.nuttall@sia.gr)